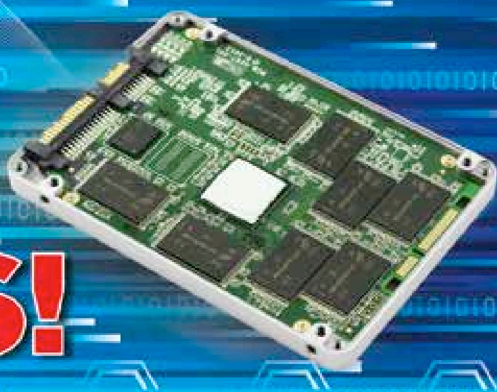
SOLID STATE DECISIONS!



With SSDs now being affordable, you no longer really have an excuse to not get one

Mithun Mohandas
mithun.mohandas@digit.in

Affordability is what comes to mind when we think of SSDs. About a year and a half back when we tested SSDs, we saw that most of the SSDs were components that only enthusiasts would purchase. Now when we look at the prices of SSDs we can't help but wonder why on earth we aren't purchasing one for ourselves. A 120 GB SSD, which is more than enough for the average user, costs around ₹5,000 which easily fits into a mid-range configuration. Moreover, SSDs have topped the SATA III bandwidth long ago so picking an SSD came down to the controller's performance and the SSD's characteristics across different data sizes and queue depths.

With the Z97 and the X99 motherboards, the NGFF (Next-Generation Form Factor) or M.2 SSD form factor was introduced and this versatile standard is creating waves in the segment. There are plenty of SKUs available in the market but we don't see it being adopted that widely in the Indian market since the motherboards that support the M.2 ports do come at a slight price premium. Now, a few of you might want to stick the proverbial finger up our noses and 'educate' us that this isn't the case. Hold on to your horses, we aren't talking about M.2 ports that only support SATA drives, but the ones that support PCIe drives. This is where the real fun comes in. ASRock has even started fiddling around with the PCIe lanes that are linked to the M.2 port. On its ASRock Z97 Extreme6 motherboard, it has implemented what it calls the Ultra M.2 port. They've used PCIe lanes directly from the processor and these lanes are PCIe 3.0 rather than PCIe 2.0 which is found on motherboards. With a theoretical bandwidth of 3.2 GB/s this sure has a rather tall upper limit for bandwidth. If more manufacturers were to implement similar setups then we'd see a rapid shift towards SSDs with higher bandwidths.

Right now, getting high speeds would involve investing in PCIe SSDs which, in turn, eat up an entire PCIe slot that could otherwise be populated with a graphics card. So enthusiasts don't have much of an option other than to use SSDs in RAID.

SOMETHING ON THE HORIZON

The SandForce 3700 controller has been in the news for quite a while and we've even heard of a few SSD launches with that chipset. The SF3719, SF3729 and SF3739 are the ones that we are concerned with and they're geared towards the entry-level, mainstream and the enthusiast markets respectively. The entry-level SSDs use Phison controllers which aren't consistent across different conditions. Hopefully, that should change with the SF3719 which is not only power optimised and cheap but is also rumoured to be much better, given that the bare minimum performance